

“**[The] 50–50 chance** of saving South Vietnam is **worth trying.**”

GENERAL LAWTON COLLINS, US SPECIAL REPRESENTATIVE IN VIETNAM, 1955

KEY CONCEPT

RELIGION IN VIETNAM

Confucianism and Buddhism were the main belief systems in Vietnam, but Catholics constituted a large minority of about two million. The Hoa Hao, who followed their own strand of Buddhism, and the Cao Dai (shown right), who practiced a syncretist religion established in the 1920s, had their own militias, both suppressed by Diem in 1955.



» **AFTER**

North Vietnamese communists sought to take advantage of growing discontent in rural South Vietnam.

TENSIONS MOUNT

In May 1959, the North Vietnamese communist leadership sent activists to organize an **armed uprising** in rural areas of South Vietnam, where Diem's rule was seen as corrupt and biased toward large landowners. **Buddhists also resented Diem** for favoring Vietnam's Catholic minority. The number of **US advisers** in Vietnam exceeded 3,000 by early 1962.